One Small Word Steals the Victory Speech

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From Michigan to the Middle East, many Arabs are celebrating Abdul El-Sayed's Senate victory and one small word from his victory speech. El-Sayed, the son of Egyptian immigrants, won a Senate seat in Michigan and will be the first Muslim American U.S. senator. At his Election Night rally in Detroit on November 4, he opened with a playful greeting for Vice President JD Vance: 'JD, **habibi**.' Vance had warned during the campaign that El-Sayed would lead rioters in burning down Detroit. El-Sayed noted the irony that Vance is **constitutionally** obligated to swear him in as a senator in January. '**Habibi**' literally means 'my beloved' in Arabic, and it shows up often in Arab pop songs. In everyday speech, it usually means something closer to 'buddy,' 'pal,' or 'bro.' El-Sayed's supporters wore shirts reading '**Habibi** for Abdul.' In his speech, El-Sayed also said his campaign had turned '**inshallah**,' meaning 'God willing,' into '**hamdulillah**,' meaning 'thank God.' The lighthearted moment struck a chord. People shared music video clips featuring the word '**habibi**' on social media, and one user joked that a song by Egyptian singer Shireen Abd El-Wahab could become the new national anthem. Egyptian academic Khalil al-Anani called '**habibi**' the sweetest word and thanked the senator-elect for bringing joy to Egyptians. Egyptians are known across the Arab world for their sense of humor, often joking even in hard times. The celebration stood out in a region shaped by past and present conflicts, which have also fed negative **stereotypes** about Arabs in the West. El-Sayed faced harsh rhetoric during the campaign. President Donald Trump called him a 'jihadist,' brought up the September 11 attacks, and repeatedly misstated his name. In his speech, El-Sayed answered with a joke of his own, telling Trump that after Vance swears him in, the president can simply call him 'senator.'

Word Treasure

Habibi -- An Arabic word meaning 'my beloved,' often used like 'buddy' or 'bro.'

inshallah -- An Arabic phrase meaning 'God willing.'

hamdulillah -- An Arabic phrase meaning 'thank God.'

constitutionally -- In a way required by a country's constitution, its most important set of rules.

stereotypes -- Unfair, oversimplified ideas about a whole group of people.

Background you need

Habibi is an Arabic word that literally means my beloved, and in everyday speech it is often used more like buddy, pal, or bro.

It is a warm and friendly word that shows up often in Arab pop songs and in everyday conversation among friends and family.

A senator is a member of the lawmaking body of the United States, and the vice president is the person who swears a new senator in, which gave the playful greeting in the victory speech an extra layer of meaning.

The word became a lighthearted rallying point for supporters celebrating the win of the first Muslim American U.S. senator, the son of Egyptian immigrants.

Break it down

LEAD: Abdul El-Sayed, the son of Egyptian immigrants, won a Senate seat in Michigan and will be the first Muslim American U.S. senator, and one small word from his victory speech is being celebrated by many Arabs.

KEY EVENT: At his Election Night rally in Detroit on November 4, El-Sayed opened with a playful greeting for Vice President JD Vance: 'JD, habibi.'

+- WHO: Abdul El-Sayed, the senator-elect; Vice President JD Vance; President Donald Trump; Egyptian academic Khalil al-Anani; and El-Sayed's supporters.

+- WHERE: Detroit, Michigan, with celebrations reaching from Michigan to the Middle East.

+- WHEN: Election Night, November 4, with Vance set to swear El-Sayed in as a senator in January.

+- WHAT THE WORD MEANS: 'Habibi' literally means 'my beloved' in Arabic and usually means something closer to 'buddy,' 'pal,' or 'bro' in everyday speech.

EVIDENCE: Supporters wore shirts reading 'Habibi for Abdul'; people shared music video clips featuring the word on social media; and El-Sayed said his campaign had turned 'inshallah,' meaning 'God willing,' into 'hamdulillah,' meaning 'thank God.'

CONTRAST: Vance had warned during the campaign that El-Sayed would lead rioters in burning down Detroit, and Trump called him a 'jihadist,' brought up the September 11 attacks, and repeatedly misstated his name.

OPEN QUESTION: El-Sayed joked that after Vance swears him in, the president can simply call him 'senator' -- leaving open how the lighthearted moment will shape the way he is received in Washington.

Why it matters

The moment shows how a single word can push back against negative stereotypes about Arabs and turn harsh campaign rhetoric into shared laughter. It also matters because El-Sayed will be the first Muslim American U.S. senator, so his victory is a milestone for representation.

Test what you remember

1. What did Abdul El-Sayed say to Vice President JD Vance at the start of his victory speech?

- (A) 'Thank you, Michigan.'
- (B) 'Good luck in January.'
- (C) 'Welcome to Detroit.'
- (D) 'JD, habibi.'

2. What does the Arabic word 'habibi' literally mean?

- (A) 'My beloved'
- (B) 'God willing'
- (C) 'Thank God'
- (D) 'My friend from Detroit'

3. According to the article, what is Vance constitutionally obligated to do in January?

- (A) Apologize for his campaign warning
- (B) Campaign with El-Sayed in Michigan
- (C) Swear El-Sayed in as a senator
- (D) Introduce El-Sayed to President Trump

4. In his speech, El-Sayed said his campaign had turned 'inshallah' into what?

- (A) 'Hamdulillah'
- (B) 'Senator'
- (C) 'Detroit'
- (D) 'Habibi'

5. What did President Donald Trump call El-Sayed during the campaign?

- (A) A 'jihadist'
- (B) The first Muslim American senator
- (C) A 'pal'
- (D) A 'buddy'

6. Who called 'habibi' the sweetest word and thanked the senator-elect for bringing joy to Egyptians?

- (A) President Donald Trump
- (B) Shireen Abd El-Wahab
- (C) JD Vance
- (D) Egyptian academic Khalil al-Anani

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: C 4: A 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Abdul El-Sayed and his supporters: They celebrated the victory with humor, wearing shirts reading 'Habibi for Abdul' and treating the greeting as a joyful, lighthearted moment.

2. Vice President JD Vance: He had warned during the campaign that El-Sayed would lead rioters in burning down Detroit.

3. President Donald Trump: He called El-Sayed a 'jihadist,' brought up the September 11 attacks, and repeatedly misstated his name during the campaign.

4. Egyptian academic Khalil al-Anani: He called 'habibi' the sweetest word and thanked the senator-elect for bringing joy to Egyptians.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):